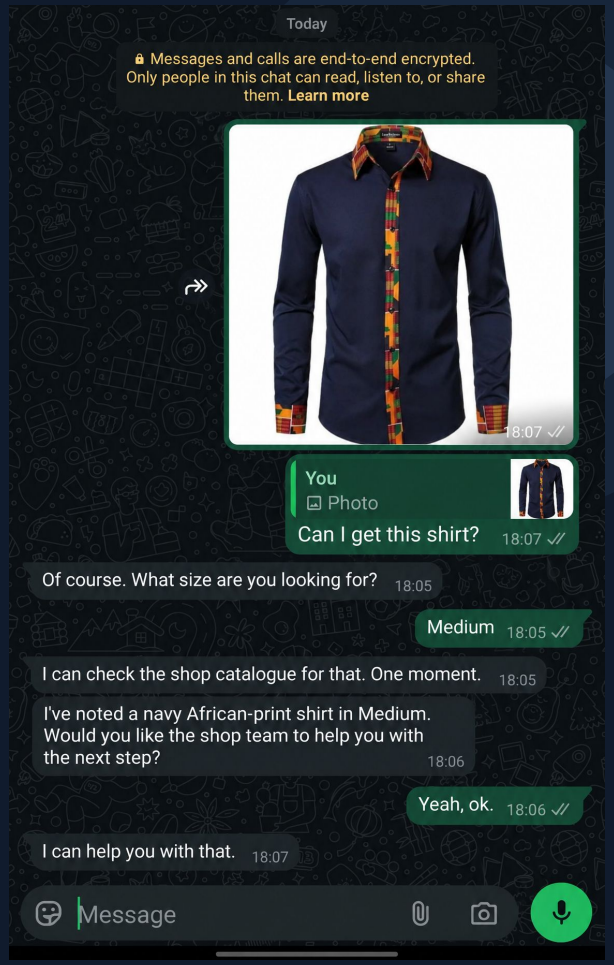
META AI DEVELOPER HACKATHON / STARTUP TRACK

THE STOREFRONT MOVED INTO THE CHAT.

SokoPilot helps small shops serve customers on WhatsApp with catalogue-grounded answers and a clear path to the merchant.

AFRICA-FIRST • HUMAN-LED

The WhatsApp sales copilot for small merchants



Ask → clarify → ground → hand off

In Kenya, commerce already has a digital front door.

23.4M

Internet users in Kenya / end of 2025 [1]

WhatsApp 19.8% • Facebook 18.2% [3]

FAMILIAR CUSTOMER CHANNEL

WhatsApp is a familiar customer channel in Kenya. Slow replies and repeated product questions can interrupt a buying conversation.

THE HIGH-FREQUENCY COMMERCE MOMENTS

01	“Is it in stock?”	AVAILABILITY
02	“Which size fits?”	VARIANT & FIT
03	“What’s the price?”	PRICE & BUDGET
04	“Can I send a photo?”	IMAGE QUESTION
05	“Can I speak to the shop?”	HUMAN HELP

AI chat isn’t the product. A better next step in a buying conversation is.

[1] DataReportal Digital 2026: Kenya; end-2025 internet figures. [3] MCK 2025: information use, not commerce conversion.

The next storefront is conversational

Customers ask, compare, and decide in chat. Small merchants need accurate product answers and a clear path to a person.

SELL WHERE YOUR CUSTOMERS ARE

Answer product questions in the channel customers already use. Ground details, then make the next step clear.

DISCOVERY

What should I buy?

DECISION

Can I trust this answer?

Small businesses need reliable product facts and an easy path to a person.

A WhatsApp sales assistant built around merchant control.

Meet customers on WhatsApp. Ground answers in the catalogue. Keep the merchant in control.

01

CONNECTED NUMBER

Connected WhatsApp Business / Cloud API number

→

02

GROUND

Merchant catalogue / Current product facts

→

03

ASSIST

Clarify • recommend • look up

→

04

CONTROL

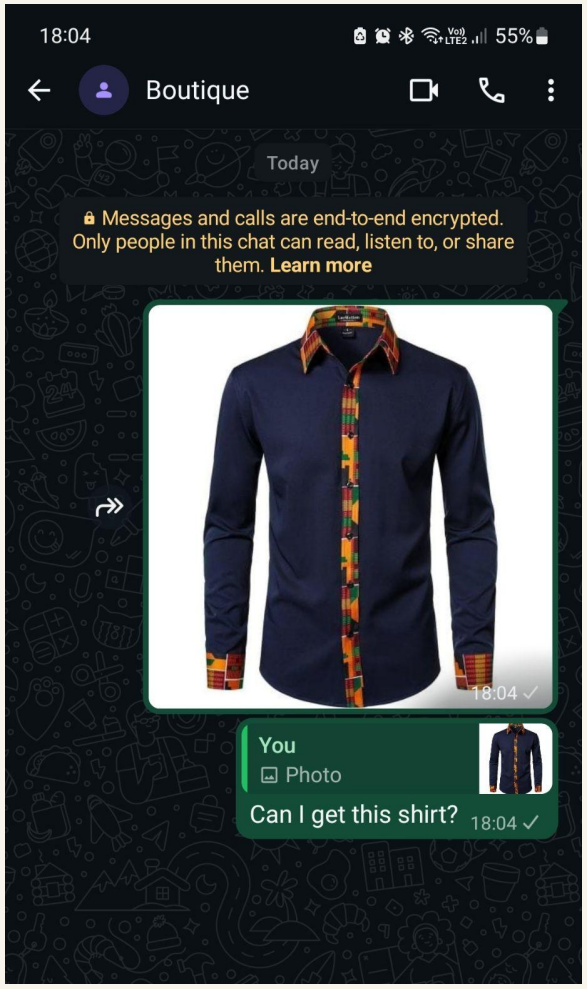
Guided choices / Pause or hand off to a person

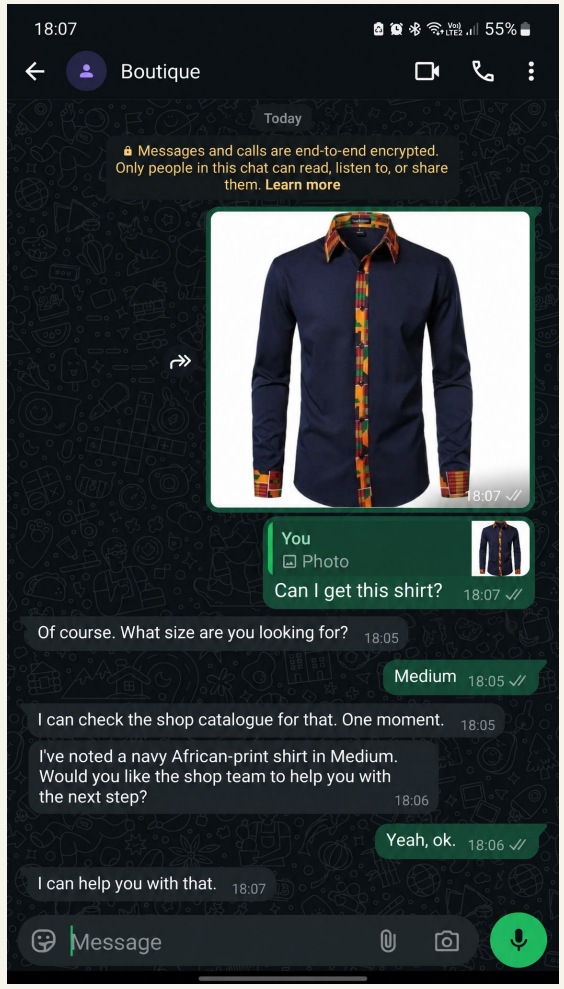
REAL-WORLD USE

A boutique answers “does this come in medium?” A customer can also send a photo. The assistant checks catalogue facts and hands uncertain questions to the merchant.

A customer does not need a full product catalogue

They need accurate product facts, a helpful response, and a trustworthy next step.





Grounded, not guessed

Catalogue answers should use the merchant's saved product details.

Clarify before acting

The assistant asks a follow-up question when useful details are missing.

Confirmation is not payment

The assistant does not create orders or process payments. A merchant handles the next step.

AI proposes. SokoPilot checks. Merchants stay in control.

The configured Meta model handles text and image questions. Scoped tools look up catalogue facts or hand the conversation to a merchant.

01 **WHATSAPP** Text or image message

02 **SOKOPILOT ROUTER** STOP opt-out • rules • handoff

03 **AI ASSISTANT** Multi-turn context + tool request

04 **SCOPED TOOLS** Catalogue search • merchant handoff

SERVER-SIDE GUARANTEES

- **Ownership** — Merchant and customer scope checked.
- **Catalogue facts** — Product details come from the merchant catalogue.
- **Webhook deduplication** — Repeated provider events are deduplicated.
- **Human takeover** — Pauses AI and auto-reply until resumed.

Model never sets price, stock or payment truth

Guardrail: merchants can test before going live.

Edit shop-specific instructions, preview replies, and keep a human in control.

BUILT-IN GUARDRAILS

01	CUSTOMIZE	Edit shop-specific instructions
02	PREVIEW	Test before activation
03	GROUND FACTS	Lookup before product claims
04	HAND OFF	Hand off to a person
05	RESUME	Merchant resumes when ready

MERCHANT SETTINGS

Editable shop instructions

Preview before activation

HUMAN IN CONTROL

Handoff pauses automation; a merchant can resume it from the conversation.

PAYMENT BOUNDARY

No order or payment tools are enabled.

Preview configuration before activation; catalogue facts stay merchant-owned.

Three layers in SokoPilot

Built for WhatsApp commerce: Meta model calls, catalogue guardrails, and human control.

META MODEL API

AI

Prompt preview + assistant runs / Meta model API

CATALOGUE GUARDRAILS

- **Catalogue search / Lookup before product claims / No order or payment tools**

MERCHANT CONTROL

- **Inbox + visible status / Takeover + human reply / Resume assistant**

SUPPORTED IN THE CURRENT BUILD

WhatsApp Cloud API

Signed inbound events and interactive customer replies

TEXT + IMAGE

Image retrieval for model analysis and merchant review

HUMAN HANDOFF

Conversation history, image, and merchant reply in one inbox

A focused two-minute SokoPilot walkthrough

A boutique use-case: https://youtu.be/SeSYVv5img0



Why now? A familiar channel and changing AI landscape

[1] KENYA DIGITAL CONTEXT

DataReportal Digital 2026: Kenya reports 23.4 million internet users and 40.5% penetration at the end of 2025.

datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-kenya

META'S SMALL-BUSINESS AI

In May 2026 Meta announced WhatsApp Business AI for small businesses in India. That market-specific rollout does not establish availability or demand in Kenya.

about.fb.com/news/2026/05/introducing-business-ai-on-whatsapp-for-small-businesses-in-india/

[3] WHATSAPP IN KENYA

MCK State of the Media 2025: WhatsApp (19.8%) led Facebook (18.2%) among platforms named for social/digital information use—not commerce reach or conversion.

mediacouncil.or.ke/sites/default/files/downloads/State%20of%20the%20Media%202025%20Survey%20Report%20FINAL.pdf

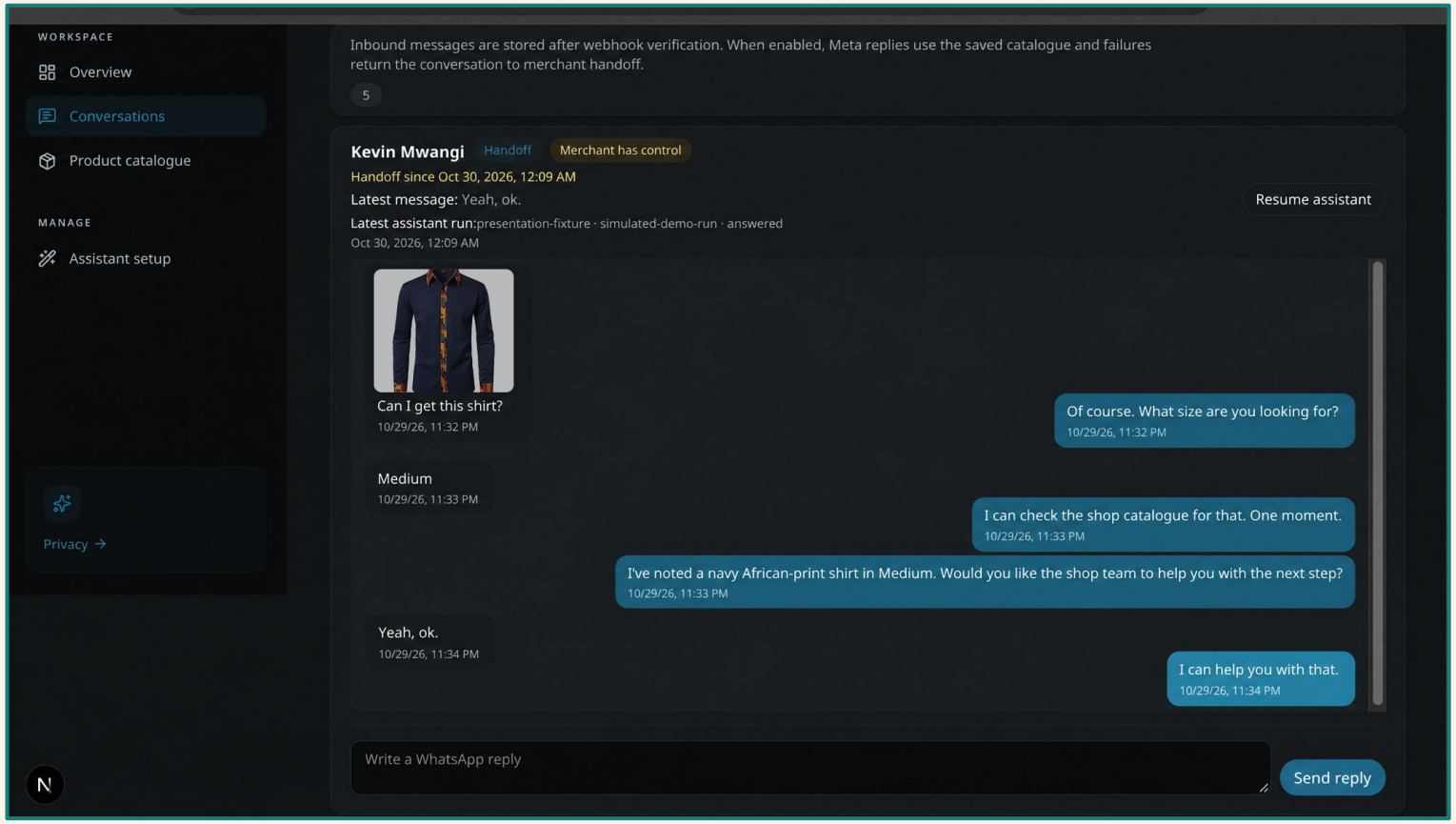
[4] PRODUCT READINESS

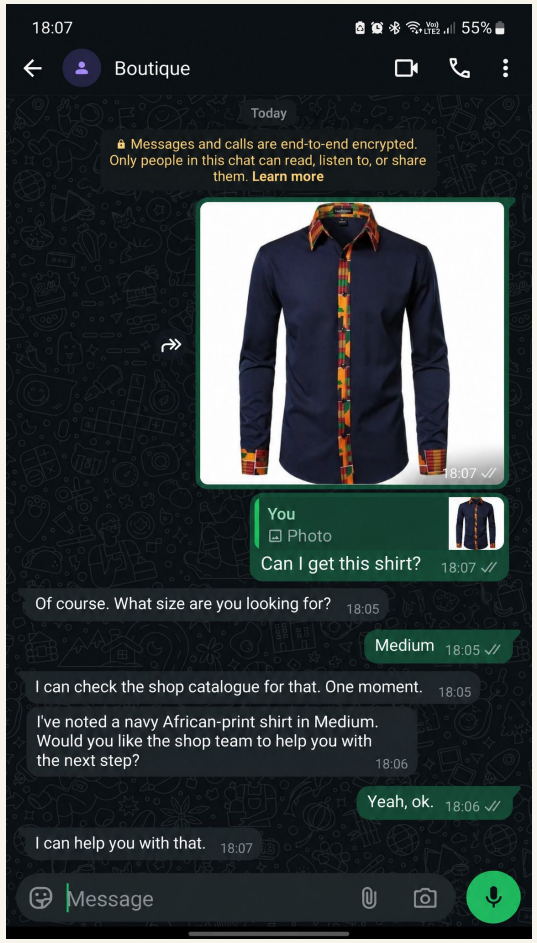
Currently a prototype

SokoPilot supports catalogue questions and merchant handoff. It dcan create orders, send payment links (not fully tested) and detect stalled conversations.

Sources: DataReportal 2026; Media Council of Kenya 2025; Meta 2026. Audience figures provide channel context, not commerce outcomes.

Merchant Workspace & User Whatsapp UI





Stalled sales, recovered with merchant approval

- **Detect**: open conversation, shop replied last, quiet 4+ hours, earlier buying or price signal, no opt-out, no pending order.
- **Review**: evidence-backed queue (Dashboard → Sales recovery) — see the triggering message before anything is sent.
- **Approve**: eligibility re-checked at send time, inside WhatsApp's 24-hour window; claimed before sending so it can never duplicate.
- **Audit**: reason, evidence, reviewer decision, and provider message ID recorded for every opportunity.
- **Status**: code-complete and tested, off by default.

Ran the evaluation. 20 of 24 passed — failures included

- Versioned set sokopilot-assistant-v1 (24 scenarios) against the configured live model muse-wonder-1.0, via npm run eval:assistant.
- **Passed**: catalogue grounding, clarification, human handoff, prompt-injection resistance, order/payment boundary refusals, Kiswahili price and stock.
- **Failures**: discount request (truncated reply), cross-tenant request (refused, no handoff), Kiswahili objection and bundle request (no catalogue search).
- **Latency p50 8.6s / p95 13.3s** — above our 10s target.
- **Catalogue evidence is now inspectable**: product/variant IDs and a retrieval timestamp on every tool result.

Next steps

1. Validate and activate the **Sales Recovery functionality** in production.
2. Fix the minimal evaluation failures; run additional test cases and analyse results to ensure benchmarks are met.
3. verify accuracy of image processing capabilities against models and get implementation edge cases requiring guardrails.
4. Stress test pipelines involving automatic outreach, payments, order creation and ERP integrations.
5. The ask: pilot merchants who will measure time-to-first-correct-reply with us.

Our Ask

As we scale into production !

Production AI piloting

SokoPilot speaks to real customers — it is paramount to test and ensure deterministic behavior

A clear runway on WhatsApp

staging WABA with test numbers, and fast-tracked app and template review. Review timelines, not engineering, are my biggest launch blocker today

Additional Pilot / Technical partners

10–20 SMB pilot merchants in East Africa with pilot-period API credits, a named Meta technical contact for architecture review, and written confirmation that customer messages sent for inference are never used for training.

THANK YOU